



KASHIGO

2026 EDITION



WALK THE GHATS

A Self-Guided Audio Tour of Varanasi
Assi to Manikarnika

NARRATED AUDIO + ROUTE CARD

Walk the Ghats

*A Self-Guided Audio Tour of Varanasi — Assi to
Manikarnika*



VAIBHAV UPADHYAY • KASHIGO

KASHIGO • VARANASI • 2026

Walk the Ghats: A Self-Guided Audio Tour of Varanasi — Assi to Manikarnika

Copyright © 2026 Vaibhav Upadhyay / KashiGo. All rights reserved.

No part of this publication may be reproduced, distributed or transmitted in any form without the prior written permission of the author, except for brief quotations in reviews.

Prices, timings, rules and contact details change. Every figure in this book is a guide based on the author's local knowledge and research at the time of writing (2026) — always verify locally before you rely on it. The author accepts no liability for loss, injury or inconvenience sustained by anyone using this book. Health information is general and is not medical advice; consult a doctor or travel clinic before you travel.

First edition, 2026 · kashigo.in · Questions or corrections: reply to your purchase email — every message is read.

Contents

0. Trailer	6
1. Welcome to Kashi	8
2. Assi Ghat, Where the City Begins	12
3. Tulsi Ghat, the Poet's Steps	15
4. Bhadaini to Chet Singh Ghat, the Fort by the Water	18
5. Shivala and Hanuman Ghat, a Little South India	21
6. Harishchandra Ghat, the King Who Kept His Word	24
7. Kedar Ghat, the Mountain Comes to the River	27
8. Narad and Chausatthi Ghats, Gossip and Goddesses	30
9. Darbhanga and Munshi Ghats, Palaces in Stone	32
10. Ahilyabai Ghat, the Queen Who Rebuilt Kashi	34
11. Dashashwamedh Ghat, the Heart of the River	36
12. The Ganga Aarti, a Ceremony of Fire	39
13. Man Mandir Ghat, the Prince Who Measured the Sky	42
14. Meer and Lalita Ghats, a Piece of Nepal	44
15. Manikarnika Ghat, Where Kashi Keeps Its Promise	46
16. Scindia Ghat and the Leaning Temple	49
17. Panchganga Ghat, Where Five Rivers Meet	51
18. Taking a Boat Back South	53
19. What Kashi Gives You	56
Route Card	58

More from KashiGo61

**TRACK 0**

Trailer

Close your eyes for a moment. Somewhere a bell is ringing. Not one bell, really, but hundreds, near and far, as if the whole city is clearing its throat. There is smoke in the air, sandalwood and marigold and something older. A boatman's oar slaps the water. A man on the steps is chanting under his breath, the same line again and again, the way his father did, and his father's father.

This is Varanasi. The people who live here call it Kashi, the city of light. It is one of the oldest living cities on earth, and it faces a single river, the Ganga, along a curve of stone steps called ghats.

My name is Vaibhav. I was born and raised in Varanasi. I grew up running up and down these steps, getting scolded by priests, eating hot kachori at seven in the morning, and watching the world arrive at my doorstep with wide eyes and a slightly nervous smile.

This tour is my way of walking beside you. Put in your earphones at Assi Ghat, at the southern end of the riverfront, and we will walk north together, ghat by ghat, all the way to Manikarnika, the great burning ghat, where Kashi keeps its oldest promise.

Along the way you will meet a poet who wrote an epic on these steps. A king who escaped the British by climbing down a rope made of turbans. A god who performed ten horse sacrifices. An astronomer prince who built a stone observatory above the river. A temple that leans into the water as if it is listening. And at every stop, I will tell you what to look at, what the locals are doing, and the one small thing that will save you money, time, or a little embarrassment.

No crowd, no flag to follow. All you need is comfortable shoes, a bottle of water, and about three hours.

And if you are not in Varanasi yet, that is fine too. Make a cup of chai, sit by a window, and let the city come to you.

This is Walk the Ghats, a self-guided audio tour from Assi to Manikarnika, by KashiGo. Press play at the river. Let Kashi tell you its story.

**TRACK 1**

Welcome to Kashi

Namaste, and welcome. If you are listening to this at Assi Ghat, find somewhere to sit for a few minutes. The steps are fine. Everyone sits on the steps here, priests, students, grandmothers, goats. You are in good company.

Before we start walking, let me tell you how this tour works, and a few things I wish every visitor knew on their first day.

This tour follows the river from south to north. We begin here at Assi Ghat and walk downstream, past more than forty ghats, to Manikarnika, and if you still have the energy, a little beyond to Panchganga Ghat. The full walk is about three and a half to four kilometres along the river. With stops, stories, and a few cups of chai, it takes most people two and a half to three hours. There is no hurry. Kashi has been here for at least three thousand years. It will wait for you.

Each track is one stop. When a track ends, I will tell you which way to walk and what to look out for, and which track to play next. The rule is simple. Keep the river on your right as you walk, and you are going the right way. If you ever get confused, just look for the water. Every lane in this city eventually tumbles down to the river.

Now, about timing. There are two beautiful ways to do this walk. The first is to start at sunrise, when the river is soft and pink and the ghats are full of bathers and morning prayers. The second is to start in the late afternoon, around three or half past three, so that you arrive at Dashashwamedh Ghat in time for the evening Ganga Aarti, the great fire ceremony. The aarti follows the sunset, so it begins roughly around six in the winter months and closer to seven in summer. These times shift with the season, so ask at your guesthouse on the day. If you take the afternoon option, you may reach Manikarnika after dark. That is perfectly fine, the cremation fires burn day and night, but some people prefer to see that part in daylight, on another morning. Choose what feels right for you.

One important warning. During the monsoon, roughly from July to September, the Ganga rises, sometimes dramatically. Many of the lower steps disappear under water, and the riverside path between ghats can be completely cut off. In those months, please check the water level before you set out, and do not try to wade or climb around flooded sections. When the path is blocked, you can walk through the lanes just behind the ghats and come back down to the river further on. The stories in this tour still work wherever you are standing.

Let me give you a few things to carry. Small cash, in ten, twenty and fifty rupee notes, for chai, a flower offering, or a small lamp to float on the river. A bottle of water, because the stone holds heat and the walk is longer than it looks. A scarf or light shawl, useful for covering your shoulders at temples or your head from the sun. And shoes you can slip on and off easily, because you will remove them at some shrines.

Now the etiquette, which is mostly common sense with a Kashi accent. Dress modestly, shoulders and knees covered, and you will be treated with more warmth everywhere. Do not touch anyone's head, and do not step over people or their belongings on the steps. If you photograph a person up close, ask first, with a smile and a gesture toward your camera. Most people will say yes. Some will say no. Both answers are a gift.

And one rule above all others. At the cremation ghats, Harishchandra and Manikarnika, do not take photographs or videos. None. These are not tourist sights. They are places where families are saying goodbye to someone they love. You can watch quietly and respectfully from a distance. That is allowed, and it can be deeply moving. But the camera stays in your pocket.

Now let me tell you about what I call the unasked help rule. In Varanasi, you will meet many genuinely kind people. You will also meet people whose kindness has a price tag folded inside it. The simple test is this. If someone offers you help that you did not ask for, a free explanation, a shortcut, a friend with a boat, a better view from a balcony, a student who just wants to practise his English, smile, say no thank you, and keep walking. You lose nothing. The river will still be there in five minutes. There is no ticket to enter any ghat. They are all public and free. Nobody needs to escort you anywhere.

Toilets are not easy to find along the river. There are a few public ones near the bigger ghats, and cafés will usually let you use theirs if you buy something. Plan accordingly.

A note on pronunciation. I will use some Hindi and Sanskrit words along the way, and I will translate them as we go. Ghat means steps leading down to water. Ganga is the river, the one the world calls the Ganges. Aarti is a ceremony of light. And Mahadev, which you will hear shouted joyfully all over this city, means the great god, Lord Shiva, who, the people of Kashi will tell you, is not just worshipped here. He lives here. This is his city.

Alright. Take a sip of water. Look at the river. When you are ready, press play on track two, and let us begin at Assi.



TRACK 2

Assi Ghat, Where the City Begins

You are at Assi Ghat, the southernmost of the major ghats of Varanasi, and the place where many of us begin and end our days.

Take a look around. Assi is wide and open, with broad stone platforms that run right down toward the water. Compared to the ghats further north, it feels spacious, almost like a town square that happens to have a river instead of a fountain. Students from Banaras Hindu University, which is just a short ride south of here, come to sit and argue about philosophy and cricket. Musicians practise. Boatmen call out, boat, boat, sir, madam, boat. Tea sellers move through the crowd with steel kettles and tiny clay cups.

Look for a large peepal tree, its roots wrapped around a shrine. Beneath it, you will find a Shiva lingam, a rounded stone symbol of Lord Shiva. This is Asisangameshwar, the lord of the meeting of the Assi. Pilgrims touch it, pour water over it, and leave a flower or two. You may see someone circling the tree, murmuring a prayer. That is a normal Tuesday

here. Or a Wednesday. Or any day.

The name Assi comes from a small river, the Assi, that once joined the Ganga at this spot. Today it is mostly a narrow channel, but in the old geography of Kashi it was a sacred boundary. The holy city was said to lie between two rivers, the Varuna in the north and the Assi in the south, and that is how Varanasi got its name. Varuna plus Assi. Varanasi. Say it slowly, and you can almost hear it.

There is also a legend, and in Kashi there is always a legend. The story goes that the goddess Durga, after a fierce battle with two demons named Shumbha and Nishumbha, flung her sword away, and where it struck the earth, the Assi river began to flow. Whether you take that literally or not, it tells you something important about this city. Even the geography has a story behind it.

If you are here at dawn, you may catch Subah-e-Banaras, which means morning of Banaras. It is a gentle morning programme with Vedic chanting, a small fire ceremony, classical music, and often yoga on the steps. The crowd is mostly local. It is quieter, softer, more contemplative than the famous evening aarti further north, and I always recommend it to people who find big crowds overwhelming.

Now look at the river itself. On the far side, to the east, you will see a long sandy bank, mostly empty. Notice that. On this side, the city rises in a dense wall of temples, palaces and houses. On the other side, almost nothing. Tradition says the far bank is not an auspicious place to build or to die, and so it has been left largely open. That contrast, crowded holiness on one side, open sky on the other, is part of what makes the view from here so striking at sunrise. The sun comes up over the empty bank and pours straight onto the face of the city.

Here is my practical tip for Assi. If you want a boat ride, this is a good place to look for one, often more relaxed than the busy centre at Dashashwamedh. A fair price for a private hand-rowed boat for an hour or so is roughly eight hundred to fifteen hundred rupees, depending on

season and time of day. Agree on the price and the duration before you step in, and pay at the end.

Another small tip. Assi has some of the best chai on the riverfront. Have a cup now. You are about to walk for a while, and in Kashi, nobody starts anything important without tea.

When you are ready, face the river, then turn left. That is north. Walk along the ghats with the river on your right. You will pass a couple of smaller ghats with grand old buildings above them, and in about five minutes you will reach a ghat with tall, steep steps climbing up to the lanes. That is Tulsi Ghat. If you are unsure, ask anyone, Tulsi Ghat, and they will point. Press play on track three when you get there.

**TRACK 3**

Tulsi Ghat, the Poet's Steps

Welcome to Tulsi Ghat. Take a moment to look up the steps toward the buildings above. Somewhere up there, more than four hundred years ago, a poet sat and wrote a book that would change the spiritual life of northern India.

His name was Goswami Tulsidas. He lived in the sixteenth and early seventeenth centuries, and he is remembered here as the author of the *Ramcharitmanas*, which means the lake of the deeds of Rama. It retells the great epic of Lord Rama, the prince who was exiled to the forest, whose wife Sita was carried away, and who fought to bring her home. The older Sanskrit version, the *Ramayana*, was a text for scholars. Tulsidas did something quietly revolutionary. He wrote his version in Awadhi, a language of ordinary people. Suddenly, farmers and weavers and boatmen could hear the story of Rama in words they spoke at home.

Tradition holds that Tulsidas wrote much of this work in Kashi, and that he lived and died here, at this very ghat, which now carries his name. A

small shrine nearby is associated with him, and devotees will tell you that some of his belongings are kept with great care. Even today, if you walk through the lanes in the evening, you may hear someone singing verses from the Ramcharitmanas, especially a set of verses called the Hanuman Chalisa, in praise of the monkey god Hanuman. Those verses are often attributed to Tulsidas too. In Kashi, they are almost a second heartbeat.

Now here is my favourite thing about Tulsi Ghat. Once a year, around the month of Kartik, which falls in October or November, this ghat hosts a festival called Nag Nathaiya. For one evening, the Ganga here is imagined as the Yamuna, the river of Lord Krishna's childhood. A boy playing Krishna climbs a tree and jumps into the water, and then rises standing on a great model of the serpent Kaliya, whom Krishna is said to have defeated. Thousands of people crowd the steps and boats to watch. If you happen to be here at that time, ask a local when it is happening. It is pure joy.

Look along the ghat for any sign of a kushti akhara, a traditional wrestling ground. Varanasi has a strong old wrestling culture, and the area around Tulsi Ghat has long been known for it. Wrestlers train on soft earth mixed with oil, turmeric and buttermilk, and they pray to Hanuman before they fight. In the early morning, you may see young men doing push-ups and swinging heavy wooden clubs called gada and jodi. Please do not walk into an akhara with your shoes on. That earth is treated as sacred.

Tulsi Ghat also has a modern story. For decades, a respected local figure, Veer Bhadra Mishra, who was both a priest at the famous Sankat Mochan temple and a professor of engineering, campaigned from here to clean the Ganga. He argued something that sounds simple but was quite radical. That you can worship a river as a mother, and still have to measure its pollution like a scientist. The work he began continues through the Sankat Mochan Foundation. When you look at the water, keep both truths in your mind. It is sacred. It also needs care.

Here is a practical tip. The steps at Tulsi Ghat are steep and can be slippery, especially near the water where they are wet or mossy. Walk on the dry stone, use the side walls if you need them, and do not rush. More visitors twist an ankle on these steps than you would think.

When you are ready, keep the river on your right and walk on. You will pass a run of smaller ghats, Bhadaini, Janaki, Anandamayi and others. Look out for a big pumping station near Bhadaini, an old structure that draws river water for the city. A few minutes beyond that, about ten minutes in all, you will see a large, fort-like palace with heavy walls rising straight up from the water. That is Chet Singh Ghat. Press play on track four when you can see it.



TRACK 4

Bhadaini to Chet Singh Ghat, the Fort by the Water

As you walk, you have been passing ghats whose names tell little stories of their own. Janaki Ghat, named for Sita, who is also called Janaki. Anandamayi Ghat, linked to the much-loved twentieth-century saint Anandamayi Ma, whose ashram stands above it. Jain Ghat, close to where the Jain tradition remembers the birthplace of Suparshvanath, one of its spiritual teachers. Ghat by ghat, you are walking through the many faiths that have made their home along this river.

But now look ahead. In front of you, or just beside you, is a building unlike the others. It does not look like a temple, and it does not look like a palace built for parties. It looks like a fort. Thick walls, small windows, towers at the corners, rising straight out of the river. This is the fort of Chet Singh, and the ghat below it is called Chet Singh Ghat.

The fort is generally said to have been built in the eighteenth century by Raja Balwant Singh, who founded the line of the Kings of Benares, and then strengthened by his son, Raja Chet Singh. You might also hear the

name spelled Chait Singh. In those days, the British East India Company was steadily expanding its power across northern India, and Benares was an important, wealthy prize.

In seventeen eighty-one, the British Governor-General, Warren Hastings, came to Benares himself. He was demanding more and more money and troops from Chet Singh, and Chet Singh was resisting. Hastings ordered the Raja placed under arrest, and he was confined right here, in his own fortress by the river.

What happened next is the part every child in Varanasi knows. The local soldiers and people rose up in anger. In the confusion, Chet Singh escaped. The story goes that his followers tied their turbans together into a rope, and he slipped out through a window on the river side and climbed down to the water, where a boat was waiting. Imagine it. A king in the dark, hand over hand down a rope of cloth, the river black below him.

The uprising was serious enough that Hastings himself had to retreat from the city for a time. Eventually British forces regained control, and Chet Singh never ruled Benares again. He lived out his life in exile. But in Kashi he is remembered as a king who would not simply bow, and there is a saying still repeated in the city, half joke, half history, that mocks how Hastings fled. I will leave it to a local to tell you that one over chai.

Today the fort is quiet. Parts of it are closed, and the walls are weathered and stained by many monsoons. In the flood season, the river climbs high up its face. Take a moment to notice the height of the water marks on the stone. They tell you how dramatically the Ganga can rise.

Just beyond the fort, you will pass the Niranjani and Mahanirvani Ghats. These names come from akharas, orders of sadhus, the ascetic holy men of India. You may see a sadhu or two, in saffron or ash, sitting quietly with a small fire. Please remember the unasked help rule here, and a related one. If you want to photograph a sadhu, ask first, and agree on a small offering beforehand. Twenty to fifty rupees is respectful. If

someone poses with you uninvited and then demands money, you are not obliged to pay.

Here is my practical tip. This stretch, from Chet Singh down toward Shivala, is one of the quieter parts of the walk. It is a good place to pause, drink water, and actually look at the river without anyone selling you anything. Use it. The crowds will come later.

When you are ready, keep the river on your right and walk on. In two or three minutes you will reach Shivala Ghat, and just beyond it, Hanuman Ghat. You may notice the sound of Tamil or Telugu, and the smell of filter coffee. Press play on track five when you arrive.

**TRACK 5**

Shivala and Hanuman Ghat, a Little South India

You have reached the stretch around Shivala Ghat and Hanuman Ghat. Look up from the river toward the buildings above, and notice the details. Doorways painted with white and red patterns. Women with jasmine in their hair. Signboards in Tamil, Telugu or Kannada script alongside Hindi. You have walked into one of the old South Indian quarters of Kashi.

For centuries, pilgrims have come here from the far south of India, from Tamil Nadu, Karnataka, Andhra Pradesh and Kerala, often travelling for weeks. Many came to spend their last years in Kashi, because, as you will hear again and again on this walk, to die in Kashi is believed to bring moksha, liberation from the cycle of birth and death. Some stayed. Their families stayed. Priests followed to serve them, and over generations, a whole South Indian neighbourhood grew up around these ghats, with its own temples, its own festivals and, very importantly, its own breakfast. If you see a small place selling idli, dosa or filter coffee in the lanes,

consider it a pilgrimage of a different kind.

The great Tamil poet Subramania Bharati lived in this neighbourhood as a young man, around the turn of the twentieth century. The house associated with him still stands in the lanes nearby, and people from Tamil Nadu come to see it.

Hanuman Ghat takes its name from a temple to Hanuman, the monkey god of strength and devotion, whom we met in Tulsidas's verses. Tradition here connects the ghat with Tulsidas himself, who is said to have founded Hanuman shrines in different parts of the city. This ghat is also home to the Juna Akhara, one of the largest orders of sadhus in India. And it is associated with Vallabhacharya, a great teacher of the fifteenth and early sixteenth centuries, who founded a devotional path centred on Lord Krishna. Tradition links him closely with Kashi, and with this part of the river in particular, and a shrine nearby honours that connection.

Look down at the water's edge. In the morning, you will see people bathing here with a rhythm that is almost choreographed. They step into the river, face the rising sun, cup water in their hands, and pour it back as an offering while reciting a mantra. Three dips, sometimes more. Then they climb out, change behind a towel with remarkable modesty and skill, and go home to start the day. This ritual bath is called *snan*. For many families here, it has happened every single morning for generations.

You may also see small groups of boys in white, with shaved heads and a tuft of hair at the back. They are students of Vedic schools, learning to chant the ancient texts by heart, exactly as they were chanted thousands of years ago. If you hear a sound like a slow, rolling wave of voices, rising and falling on precise notes, that is them. Stand still and listen for a while. It is one of the most beautiful sounds in this city, and it costs nothing.

Here is my practical tip. If you want to leave an offering anywhere on this walk, buy a little leaf bowl of flowers from a vendor for ten or twenty

rupees. You do not need a priest or a ceremony. Just stand at the edge of the water, hold it for a moment, and let it go. Nobody will charge you for that, and if anyone tries to, they are not a priest.

When you are ready, keep the river on your right and walk on. You will pass Karnataka Ghat, and very soon you will notice smoke rising ahead, and stacks of wood. That is Harishchandra Ghat, one of the two cremation ghats of Varanasi. Before you walk up to it, please put your camera away. Press play on track six when you are nearby.



TRACK 6

Harishchandra Ghat, the King Who Kept His Word

You are now at Harishchandra Ghat. Lower your voice a little. Just stand for a moment and take in what is in front of you.

You will see piles of wood, stacked carefully by size. You will see smoke, and perhaps one or two fires burning near the water. You may see a body, wrapped in white or bright orange cloth, decorated with marigolds, resting on a bamboo stretcher. Around it, men of the family, often with freshly shaved heads, dressed in white. This is a cremation ground, what Hindus call a shamshan. It is one of the two cremation ghats of Varanasi. The other, larger one is Manikarnika, which we will reach at the end of our walk.

Harishchandra Ghat is often said to be the older of the two. It takes its name from one of the most loved stories in India, the story of King Harishchandra.

Harishchandra was a king famous for never telling a lie and never breaking a promise. The legend says that the sage Vishwamitra decided to test him, and through a series of promises and demands, the king lost his kingdom, his wealth, and finally his own freedom. He was separated from his wife and son, and he ended up here in Kashi, working for the keeper of the cremation ground, tending fires for the dead.

Then one day, his wife arrived at the ghat carrying the body of their young son, who had died of a snake bite. She had no money to pay the cremation fee. And Harishchandra, heartbroken, still would not break the rule of his work. He asked her for the fee. She offered the only thing she had, half of the cloth she was wearing. At that moment, the story says, the gods appeared, moved by a truthfulness that could not be broken even by grief. The son was restored to life, and the family to their kingdom.

You do not need to believe the ending to feel the weight of the story. Indians have told it for centuries, to children, in films, on stage. In my family, if you told a lie, someone would say, oh, look at our little Harishchandra. That was sarcasm. In Varanasi, even the scolding has mythology in it.

In the late twentieth century, an electric crematorium was added here, a practical step for families who cannot afford the large quantity of wood a traditional cremation requires. You may see its building near the ghat. Both old and new exist side by side, which is very Kashi.

Now, why do people want to be cremated here at all? Because of a belief at the heart of this city. It is said that anyone who dies in Kashi, and is cremated on the banks of the Ganga, is released from the cycle of rebirth. Some say Lord Shiva himself whispers a mantra into the ear of the dying, the taraka mantra, the mantra that carries you across. That is why you will see no wailing here, usually. Grief, yes. But also a strange calm. For the family, this is not only an ending. It is, they hope, a liberation.

Here is my practical tip, and it matters. Do not photograph or film here, not even from a distance, not even discreetly. If you are approached by someone who offers to explain the cremations or asks you for money for wood, politely decline and move on. The families have already paid for everything they need. Nobody genuine will ask a tourist for wood money.

When you are ready, keep the river on your right and walk on, past the cremation area along the path closest to the water, giving any procession plenty of room. In a few minutes you will see broad steps painted in red and white stripes, and a temple with a busy, colourful entrance above. That is Kedar Ghat. Press play on track seven when you get there.

**TRACK 7**

Kedar Ghat, the Mountain Comes to the River

Look at those steps. Bold stripes of red and white, running down toward the water like a festival ribbon. You are at Kedar Ghat, one of the most cheerful and photogenic ghats on the whole riverfront, and one of the most important to the people who live around it.

Above the ghat stands the Kedareshwar temple, dedicated to Lord Shiva as Kedarnath, the lord of Kedar. Now, if you know India, that name may surprise you. The famous Kedarnath temple is far away, high in the Himalayas, in the snow. So why is Kedarnath here, by the river, in the plains?

There is a legend for that, naturally. It is said that a devoted sage made the long, hard pilgrimage to the Himalayan Kedarnath again and again, until he grew too old to climb. Moved by his devotion, Shiva promised that he would come to Kashi instead, and appear here, so the old man could worship him without the mountain. And so, the story goes, the lord of the high snows took up residence beside the Ganga. Local people say

that a visit to Kedareshwar in Kashi is as meritorious as the journey to the Himalayas. I am a Varanasi boy, so I will not argue with that.

In Kashi, the city is often described in three parts, each said to rest under the special care of a form of Shiva. The southern part is associated with Kedareshwar, the middle with Vishweshwar, which is Kashi Vishwanath, and the north with Omkareshwar. So in a sense, you have just entered Shiva's southern district. Walk respectfully. You are in his neighbourhood.

Like the area around Hanuman Ghat, Kedar Ghat has a strong South Indian and also Bengali presence. Many of the families around here have roots in other parts of India, sometimes going back many generations. You will hear several languages being spoken on these steps, and you will see a beautiful mix of styles in the way people dress, pray and decorate their homes.

Near the bottom of the steps, look for a small pool or tank of water, known as Gauri Kund. Pilgrims bathe or sprinkle themselves with its water, which is believed to have healing qualities. You may also see women in bright saris lighting small lamps or tying threads as they make a wish.

If you want to step into the temple, remove your shoes at the bottom of the entrance stairs, where you will often find someone minding footwear for a small fee. Ten or twenty rupees is normal. Photography is usually not allowed inside temples in Kashi, so keep your phone away once you are inside. Follow what others do. Ring the bell gently as you enter, and you are part of the morning chorus.

Here is my practical tip. Kedar Ghat is one of the best spots for photographs of the ghats themselves, especially in the morning light, with the stripes, the temple and the boats together in one frame. Take your pictures from a little distance, and if people are bathing, frame your shot so you are not photographing them up close without asking.

When you are ready, keep the river on your right and walk on. You will pass a cluster of smaller ghats, Chauki, Kshemeshwar, Mansarovar, and then Narad Ghat, followed shortly by Chausatthi Ghat. Look for a tall, narrow staircase climbing steeply into the lanes. Press play on track eight as you walk through this stretch.



TRACK 8

Narad and Chausatthi Ghats, Gossip and Goddesses

As you walk this stretch, the ghats come thick and fast. Some are just a set of steps and a doorway. Others have whole palaces rising behind them. Many were built by kings and nobles from all over India, from Rajasthan, from Nepal, from Maharashtra, from Bengal, who wanted a foothold in the holiest city and a house where they could stay on pilgrimage. So as you walk, you are really walking past the embassies of old India.

Look out for Mansarovar Ghat, named after the holy lake at the foot of Mount Kailash in Tibet, Shiva's mountain home. Once again, the faraway sacred is brought right here to Kashi. The people of this city have a habit of doing that. Why travel to a holy place when you can invite it over?

Then comes Narad Ghat. It is named after Narada, the wandering sage of Hindu stories, who travels between heaven and earth playing his stringed instrument, chanting the name of Vishnu, and, frankly, starting a good deal of trouble. Narada is the gossip of the gods. He carries news, he stirs

things up, and somehow everything turns out for the best in the end.

There is a local belief, told mostly with a grin, that married couples should not bathe here together, or that women who bathe here may end up quarrelling with their husbands. Is it true? I have no data. But I have seen more than one uncle steer his wife firmly toward the next ghat. In Kashi, even the superstitions have a sense of humour.

A little further on, you will reach Chausatthi Ghat. Chausath means sixty-four. Above this ghat, up in the lanes, is a temple to the Chausath Yogini, the sixty-four yoginis, powerful goddess figures linked to the Tantric traditions of India. In old Kashi, these goddesses were believed to guard the city. One legend says they were sent to Kashi on a mission and were so enchanted by the city that they never left. That, by the way, is a very common story in Varanasi. Gods, kings, sages, foreigners. They come for a few days, and they stay for years. Consider yourself warned.

Here is my practical tip. This part of the riverfront is where you may first meet the young men who say they are students and just want to practise their English, or who offer to show you the hidden Varanasi. Some are genuinely friendly. Many are leading you to a silk shop or a guesthouse that pays them a commission. Remember the unasked help rule. A smile, a no thank you, and a few more steps along the river solve almost everything.

When you are ready, keep the river on your right and walk on. In a minute or two you will see a tall, majestic sandstone palace with pillared balconies and arched windows rising high above the ghat. You will know it when you see it. That is Darbhanga Ghat. Press play on track nine.



TRACK 9

Darbhangha and Munshi Ghats, Palaces in Stone

Stop here, and look up. Keep looking up. This is one of the most impressive buildings on the entire riverfront.

Rising above you is a grand palace of pale sandstone, with tall columns, carved balconies, and rows of windows that seem to watch the river like eyes. It sits across two neighbouring ghats, Munshi Ghat and Darbhanga Ghat, and if you are standing on the steps below it, it can feel like a cliff made by human hands.

The story of this building is a tale of two owners. The older part is usually dated to the early nineteenth century, to around eighteen twelve, and is credited to a man named Shridhara Narayan Munshi, who served as a minister to the Maratha state of Nagpur. That is why one of the ghats is called Munshi Ghat. A little over a hundred years later, around nineteen fifteen, the palace was acquired by the Maharaja of Darbhanga, a wealthy ruling family from Bihar, and the ghat next door came to be known as Darbhanga Ghat.

Notice the architecture. It is a mix of styles. You can see Greek-looking columns, Rajput-style balconies, and Indian arches, all blended together, rather like the city itself. There is a lovely detail in its history, too. It is said that an early lift, an elevator, was installed here in the early twentieth century, among the first of its kind in India. Picture a Maharaja in silk gliding up a lift shaft above the Ganga, while pilgrims below climbed every step on foot. Kashi has always held these contrasts calmly.

Today, this palace has been restored and converted into a heritage hotel. So the balconies you see above may have guests drinking tea in them, looking down at you, while you look up at them. Wave, if you like. It is a very Varanasi exchange.

Now look a little to either side. Notice how the ghats here are dense with buildings, one after another, many several storeys high, many slightly crooked, many painted in fading colours. Notice too the platforms jutting out over the water, and the large umbrellas, made of bamboo and cane, under which priests sit. Those priests are called ghatiyas, or pandas. They sit there each morning to help pilgrims with rituals, to mark foreheads with sandalwood paste, and to look after bathers' belongings. Some families have held their spot on a particular ghat for many generations. That umbrella is, in a sense, a family office.

Here is my practical tip. If you want a good view of these palaces in their full height, the best place is actually from the water. If you plan to take a boat later, at sunrise or at the end of this walk, ask the boatman to pass close to Darbhanga and Munshi Ghats. From the river, the whole palace front catches the light, and you will understand why so many painters and photographers come here.

When you are ready, keep the river on your right and walk on. Very soon, you will reach Ahilyabai Ghat, named after a remarkable queen. Press play on track ten when you get there.



TRACK 10

Ahilyabai Ghat, the Queen Who Rebuilt Kashi

You are at Ahilyabai Ghat, and I want to introduce you to one of the most important women in the history of this city, and one of my personal heroes.

Her name was Ahilyabai Holkar. She lived in the eighteenth century and ruled the Maratha kingdom of Malwa, in central India, from her capital near the Narmada river. She became queen after her husband and her father-in-law died, and at a time when women were rarely allowed to hold real power, she ran her kingdom for nearly thirty years with such fairness and good sense that people still speak of her with deep affection.

Ahilyabai was devoted to Shiva, and she used her wealth not to build palaces for herself, but to repair and build temples, ghats, rest houses and wells across the whole of India, from the Himalayas to the far south. Varanasi was especially close to her heart. Around the late eighteenth century, she rebuilt the great Kashi Vishwanath temple, which stands in the lanes not far from here and is the most important temple in this city.

The ghat you are standing on, built around the same period, carries her name. It is said that before her, this spot was known by another name, and that she gave it new life.

Why does that matter? Because in Varanasi, so much that you see is not as old as it looks. The city is ancient, its traditions are ancient, but many of its buildings have been destroyed and rebuilt, again and again. Kashi has survived invasions, fires, floods and neglect, and every time, someone has picked up the stones and started again. Ahilyabai is perhaps the most famous of those rebuilders. When you walk through Kashi, you are often walking through her generosity.

If you are walking in the late afternoon, notice how the light changes as you approach the centre of the riverfront. The sun goes down behind the city, so the ghats slowly fall into shadow while the far bank and the river still glow. The water goes from silver to gold to copper. If you are here in the early morning, it is the opposite. The sun rises over the empty bank across the water and lights up every face of every building in front of you. Either way, take a moment. This is a good place to watch the river change colour.

Here is my practical tip. From here on, you will be approached more often by people selling small lamps called diyas. A diya here is a little leaf cup with marigold petals and a small candle or wick. It is a beautiful thing to float on the river at dusk, and a fair price is about ten to twenty rupees. If someone asks for much more, smile and buy from the next child. There will be one in about four seconds.

When you are ready, keep the river on your right and walk on. In a few minutes, the noise will rise, the crowds will thicken, and you will see platforms, loudspeakers, big umbrellas and rows of boats. You have arrived at the heart of it all. Dashashwamedh Ghat. Press play on track eleven.



TRACK 11

Dashashwamedh Ghat, the Heart of the River

Welcome to Dashashwamedh Ghat. If Varanasi has a centre, this is it.

Take a breath, because there is a lot going on. Look around you. Wide stone steps packed with people. Rows of wooden boats nudging each other at the water's edge, their boatmen calling out. Priests under big cane umbrellas, marking foreheads with sandalwood. Flower sellers with baskets of marigolds. A man selling peanuts from a cone of newspaper. A cow, unbothered, standing exactly where everyone wants to walk. Somewhere, a loudspeaker playing devotional songs. Somewhere else, another loudspeaker, playing a different devotional song. Welcome to Kashi.

Now let me tell you why this place is called Dashashwamedh. Dash means ten. Ashwamedh is an ancient Vedic ritual, the horse sacrifice, a grand ceremony performed by kings to show their power and seek divine blessing. So Dashashwamedh means the place of the ten horse sacrifices.

The legend goes like this. Once, the god Shiva had left Kashi, and a righteous king called Divodasa was ruling the city. Shiva longed to return to his beloved Kashi, and so he sent various gods to find some fault in Divodasa's rule, so that he might be persuaded to leave. Lord Brahma, the creator, came here, and arranged to perform not one, but ten great horse sacrifices on this spot. Everything was done perfectly. And it is said that Brahma was so taken with Kashi that he too stayed on. In some tellings, Brahma established a Shiva lingam here, which is still worshipped. Whatever the details, the meaning for the people of Kashi is clear. This spot has been sacred since the time of the gods.

In more recent history, the ghat as you see it today owes a great deal to the Marathas. It is generally said to have been built up in the mid eighteenth century by the Maratha Peshwa, Balaji Baji Rao, and then rebuilt a few decades later by Queen Ahilyabai, whom we met at the last stop. So she is here too. She is everywhere in this part of Kashi.

Every evening, this ghat becomes the stage for the most famous ritual in Varanasi, the Ganga Aarti. Look for the row of raised wooden platforms near the water, usually five or seven of them, each with a cloth canopy or umbrella. That is where the priests will stand. In the next track, I will talk you through the ceremony itself, step by step. You can play it while you wait, or during the aarti, at a low volume, so you understand what you are watching.

Here are my practical tips for Dashashwamedh, and there are a few, because this is the busiest place on the river.

First, the aarti follows sunset, so its time changes. Roughly, it starts around six in the colder months and closer to seven in summer. Arrive at least forty-five minutes before it starts if you want a good spot on the steps. The crowd locks in quickly.

Second, there are no official paid seats at the aarti. If someone offers you a reserved chair or a VIP seat for a few hundred rupees, you do not need it. The steps are free, and from the upper steps you get a very good view.

Third, if you want to watch from a boat, which gives you the full panorama of all the priests at once, arrange it well in advance. A boat negotiated at the last minute on the steps often costs much more and ends up badly positioned behind other boats.

Fourth, keep your phone and wallet in a front pocket or a zipped bag. Crowds are crowds everywhere in the world.

And finally, this is where you will be offered the most unasked help of the entire walk. Friendly men who want to take you to the best spot, to a rooftop, to a boat, to a silk shop. You know the rule by now. Smile. No thank you. Keep moving.

When you are ready, if it is close to aarti time, find yourself a spot, sit down, and press play on track twelve. If it is not aarti time, you can still listen to track twelve here, or skip ahead. To continue the walk, keep the river on your right and head just a little further north to the next ghats, Prayag Ghat and Rajendra Prasad Ghat, and then Man Mandir Ghat, with its grand Rajput palace. track thirteen begins there.



TRACK 12

The Ganga Aarti, a Ceremony of Fire

If you are sitting on the steps of Dashashwamedh as the sky darkens, this track is for you. If you are listening at home, imagine it. The air is warm and thick with incense. The river is going dark. Thousands of people are pressed together on the steps and on boats packed side by side on the water. And then the bells begin.

The word aarti means a ritual of light. In every Hindu home and temple, aarti is performed by waving a lamp in circles before a deity, as an offering of light, love and gratitude. Here, the deity being honoured is Ganga herself, the river, who is worshipped as a goddess and as a mother. Ganga Maiya, people call her. Mother Ganga.

The priests who perform the aarti are young men, usually dressed in matching saffron or golden robes. They take their positions on the platforms facing the river, which means that if you are on the steps, you mostly see their backs. Do not worry. You are seeing it the way it is meant to be seen, as one of the worshippers, all of you facing the river together.

Here is roughly what will happen. The exact order varies a little, but if you know these moments, you will follow it easily.

It begins with the blowing of conch shells, a deep, sustained sound that rolls across the water. Often the conch is blown more than once, and as it sounds, the crowd falls quiet. Then the priests light incense and begin to move it in wide, slow, synchronised arcs. The smoke drifts back over the crowd, and the scent fills your chest.

Next, the lamps. The priests lift heavy brass lamps, some with many tiers of flames, and swing them in large circles, clockwise, in perfect unison. This is the moment everyone photographs. The flames trace golden rings in the darkness, and their reflections tremble on the river. Listen to the bells, the drums, the chanting, and the crowd joining in, clapping in rhythm.

The whole ceremony lasts around forty to fifty minutes. At the end, the lamps are often brought toward the crowd. People hold their palms briefly over the flame, then touch their eyes or forehead, taking the blessing of the light into themselves. You are welcome to do the same, if it feels right to you.

Afterward, many people float a diya on the river. If you bought one earlier, now is the time. Walk carefully down to the water's edge, light the little wick, close your eyes for a moment, make a wish or a prayer or simply a thank you, and set it on the water. Watch it drift away, one tiny flame among hundreds. People have done this here for longer than anyone can remember. Now you have too.

A few gentle reminders while you watch. Photographs and videos are fine at the aarti, but please do not stand up to take them if you are seated on the steps. You will block everyone behind you, and the grandmother behind you will let you know, in a voice that carries surprisingly well. Keep your belongings close. And when it ends, do not rush for the exits with everyone else. Sit for ten minutes. Let the crowd thin out. The river is beautiful right after the aarti, when the noise falls away and only the

smoke and the little lamps remain.

When you are ready to continue, keep the river on your right and walk a short way north, past Prayag Ghat and Rajendra Prasad Ghat. Look for a beautiful old palace with carved stone balconies and a decorated corner tower. That is Man Mandir Ghat. Press play on track thirteen there.



TRACK 13

Man Mandir Ghat, the Prince Who Measured the Sky

You are at Man Mandir Ghat. Look up at the palace above the steps. Notice the stone balconies with their delicate carved brackets, the latticed windows, and the elegant small pavilions on the roof. This is classic Rajput architecture, the style of the great royal houses of Rajasthan, and it is one of the finest buildings on the riverfront.

The palace is traditionally credited to Raja Man Singh of Amber, near Jaipur, a powerful general and noble at the court of the Mughal emperor Akbar. It is generally dated to around the year sixteen hundred. Man Singh was a remarkable figure, a Hindu prince who led Mughal armies across India, and who also spent a great deal of money on temples and ghats in Kashi. The ghat takes its name from him, Man Mandir, the palace of Man.

But the most fascinating part of this building is on its roof. Over a century after the palace was built, another ruler from the same royal family, Maharaja Sawai Jai Singh the Second, the founder of the city of Jaipur,

came to Kashi with a very different interest. He was obsessed with astronomy. He wanted to measure the sky more accurately than anyone in India had done before, and he built a series of great observatories in different cities. They are known as Jantar Mantar, from the Sanskrit word for instrument. The most famous ones are in Jaipur and Delhi. One of them, smaller but complete, is right here, on the roof of this palace.

Sources differ on exactly when it was added. Most accounts place it in the first half of the eighteenth century. What it contains is extraordinary. Huge stone and masonry instruments, sundials and curved scales, designed to tell time from the sun's shadow, to track the positions of stars and planets, and to help prepare calendars. Imagine astronomers up there three hundred years ago, without telescopes, measuring the heavens with stone, while below them pilgrims bathed and prayed exactly as they do today. Science and devotion, one floor apart.

The observatory is usually open to visitors as a protected monument, with a small entry fee, and the building also houses a museum and exhibits about the history of the ghats and the city. Opening hours and arrangements change, so check on the day. If it is open, it is well worth climbing up for the instruments, and for one of the best views of the river you will find anywhere on this walk.

Here is my practical tip. If you want a quick break and a snack, this central area, around Dashashwamedh and Man Mandir, is the easiest place on the riverfront to find chai, cold drinks and street food. Just step a little way up into the lanes. Look for stalls that are busy with local people and where the food is cooked fresh in front of you. That is the oldest food safety rule in India, and it still works.

When you are ready, keep the river on your right and walk on. You will pass Tripura Bhairavi Ghat and then Meer Ghat. Look up for a small temple made of dark, carved wood, with a tiered roof that looks as if it belongs in the mountains. That is the Nepali temple at Lalita Ghat. Press play on track fourteen when you see it.



TRACK 14

Meer and Lalita Ghats, a Piece of Nepal

You are now around Meer Ghat and Lalita Ghat. Look for the temple I mentioned, built of dark wood, with sloping tiled roofs stacked one on top of another, a little like a pagoda. It looks completely different from everything else on the riverfront. That is because it is not Indian in style at all. It is Nepali.

This is the Nepali temple, formally a temple of Shiva as Pashupatinath, the lord of all creatures. Pashupatinath is the great temple of Kathmandu, the holiest Hindu site in Nepal, and this building was made as a kind of homage to it, a little piece of Kathmandu by the Ganga. Locals often call it the Nepali Mandir, or sometimes Kathwala Mandir, which means the wooden temple.

The story behind it is a royal drama. Around the year eighteen hundred, King Rana Bahadur Shah of Nepal went into exile in Varanasi for several years. While he was here, he decided to build a replica of Pashupatinath. Before it could be finished, he returned to Nepal, and the project was

completed later by his son. Most accounts say it was finished around eighteen forty-three. Craftsmen and wood were brought from Nepal, and if you look closely at the carvings on the struts and beams, you will see the fine detailed woodwork for which the Kathmandu valley is famous. Some of the carvings include erotic figures, as do some old temples in Nepal and India. Do not be shocked. In these traditions, the whole of life, including love and desire, was considered part of the sacred.

Lalita Ghat itself is named after the goddess Lalita, a gentle and beautiful form of the divine mother. There is a temple to her in the area as well. And above the ghat, in recent years, a great deal has changed. The new Kashi Vishwanath corridor, a large modern complex of paved courtyards and walkways, now connects the Vishwanath temple to the river around this area. So you may see wide new steps and modern stone pavilions close to very old ghats. Some people love the new openness. Others miss the tight, ancient lanes that were cleared to make it. You will hear both opinions in Kashi, usually loudly, usually over chai.

Meer Ghat, just before Lalita, is said to be named after Mir Rustam Ali, an official in the eighteenth century. It is a reminder that Kashi was never only Hindu. Muslim rulers, officials, weavers and musicians have been part of this city for centuries. Some of the finest Banarasi silk saris, the ones brides across India dream of, are woven by Muslim families in the city's weaving neighbourhoods. Kashi is a Hindu holy city, yes. But it is also a mixed, layered, very human city.

Here is my practical tip. The Nepali temple is usually open to visitors, and there may be a small donation box. It is a lovely, quiet place to sit for a few minutes before the intensity of what comes next. Because our next stop is Manikarnika, the great cremation ghat. Take a breath here. Drink some water. And please, put your camera fully away now.

When you are ready, keep the river on your right and walk on. In just a few minutes, you will smell woodsmoke, and you will see great stacks of logs, and fires burning near the water. That is Manikarnika Ghat. Press play on track fifteen as you approach. Walk slowly. Speak softly.



TRACK 15

Manikarnika Ghat, Where Kashi Keeps Its Promise

You have arrived at Manikarnika Ghat. Find a place to stand a little back from the fires, out of the way of the paths, and just listen with me for a while.

You will hear the crackle of burning wood. The low murmur of voices. The occasional chant, rhythmic and steady. Ram naam satya hai. The name of Ram is truth. That is the chant you will hear as bodies are carried through the lanes and down to the river on bamboo stretchers, shoulder high, wrapped in cloth and flowers.

You will see wood, an enormous amount of it, stacked in towers, weighed on old scales, carried by men who have done this work all their lives. You will see several pyres burning at once, near the water. You will see the families, standing close, often silent. This is the most important cremation ground in Varanasi, and for many Hindus, the most sacred place to end a life's journey anywhere on earth. It is said that the fires here have not gone out for a very, very long time. People will tell you

centuries. Some will tell you since the beginning of time. In Kashi, both answers are considered acceptable.

Let me tell you the legends of this place, because there are several, and they braid together. Manikarnika means the jewelled earring. One story says that Lord Vishnu dug a sacred pool here with his discus, and performed intense meditation beside it. When Shiva came to see him, Shiva was so delighted that he shook with joy, and his jewelled earring fell into the pool. Another version says it was Parvati, Shiva's wife, who dropped her earring here, and in some tellings she did so on purpose, so that Shiva would have to stay and search for it, and never leave Kashi. That pool, called Manikarnika Kund, still exists, a little above and behind the ghat, though it is often hard to spot among the buildings and crowds.

The deepest belief here is the one we met at Harishchandra Ghat. That those who die in Kashi, and are cremated here by the river, are freed from the endless cycle of birth and death. Shiva himself, it is said, whispers the mantra of liberation into the ear of the dying. That is why, for centuries, the elderly and the very ill have come to Kashi to spend their last days. There are even guesthouses in the city where people come specifically to wait for death, calmly, as if waiting for a train. For many visitors, that is the hardest and most beautiful thing to understand about this city. Here, death is not hidden behind hospital walls. It is out in the open, by the river, in daylight, part of the life of the city.

The cremations are managed by a community traditionally known as the Doms, who for generations have kept the sacred fire and carried out this work. Their role is ancient, and an important part of the life of this ghat. Families typically bring the body to the river, dip it in the Ganga one last time, and then place it on the pyre. The chief mourner, usually the eldest son, walks around the pyre and lights it with fire brought from the sacred flame. After the cremation, the ashes are given to the river.

Now, please listen carefully to this part, because it is where many visitors run into trouble.

At Manikarnika, you will very likely be approached by a man who is friendly and well spoken. He may say he works at the ghat, or at a hospice, or that he is just a local who wants to explain. He will offer to tell you about the rituals, for free. He may lead you up some steps to a building with a better view. And then, gently but firmly, he will ask you to donate money for wood for the poor families who cannot afford it, often a large amount, by the kilo.

Please do not follow anyone up a staircase or onto a platform here. The families present have already arranged and paid for what they need. No genuine priest, worker or family member will ask a tourist for wood money. If someone starts explaining uninvited, say calmly, no thank you, I am just observing, and walk back toward the open riverside path. You are completely free to stand and watch quietly from a respectful distance without anyone's help.

And again, no photographs and no video. Not of the fires, not of the families, not of the wood. This rule is taken very seriously here, and rightly so.

Stay as long as feels right. Some people stay for five minutes. Some sit for an hour. There is no correct way to feel here. Many visitors find it unexpectedly peaceful. Watching the smoke rise over the river, you may find yourself thinking about your own life, the people you love, the things that matter, and the many things that do not. That is what this place has been doing to people for a very long time.

When you are ready, keep the river on your right and walk on, past the cremation area, keeping to the side and well clear of the pyres and the procession routes. Just beyond, at the water's edge, you will see a temple leaning at a steep angle, its base sunk into the river. Press play on track sixteen there.



TRACK 16

Scindia Ghat and the Leaning Temple

Look toward the river's edge, between Manikarnika and Scindia Ghat. You will see it. A temple, tall and slender, tilted sharply to one side, its lower part sitting in the water or the riverbank mud. It looks as if it is bowing to the Ganga, or listening to something the river is whispering.

This is usually identified as the Ratneshwar Mahadev temple, a Shiva temple in the Nagara style of north India, with a tall curved tower. It leans at a remarkable angle, often said to be around nine degrees, which is more than the famous leaning tower of Pisa. Because it stands so low, close to the water, it is submerged for months of the year when the river rises, sometimes right up to its tower.

Why does it lean? The honest answer is that the riverbank here is soft and shifting, and heavy stone buildings sink. But Kashi does not settle for only the honest answer. There are several stories. One popular version says the temple was built by a woman named Ratna Bai, a maidservant, in some versions to a queen, in honour of her own mother. When asked

to name it after her royal patron, she refused, and named it after herself instead, and the temple was cursed to lean. Another version says a son built it to repay his debt to his mother, and the temple tilted to show that no one can ever repay a mother's love. I like that one. Every mother in Varanasi likes that one.

Just next to it is Scindia Ghat. It was built in the nineteenth century, around eighteen thirty, by the Scindia royal family of Gwalior, often credited to Maharani Baiza Bai Scindia. Notice its massive stone structure, rising high from the water. There is a story that during construction, the ghat was so heavy that it partly collapsed into the river, and that is one reason so much of the riverbank here seems to tilt and sag.

Scindia Ghat also has a legend of its own. It is said to be the place where Agni, the god of fire, was born. Above the ghat, in the lanes, there are many small shrines, and this area is traditionally considered one of the very old and sacred parts of Kashi.

Here is my practical tip. This is a wonderful place to rest after Manikarnika. Scindia Ghat is usually calmer, and the steps are a good place to sit, sip water, and watch the river. From here, you can see the whole curve of the ghats sweeping back south toward Dashashwamedh and Assi. Look back at how far you have walked.

You now have a choice. If you have energy left, keep the river on your right and walk about ten minutes further north to Panchganga Ghat, where a large old mosque with white domes stands high above the steps. Press play on track seventeen there. If you are tired, or it is getting late, skip to track eighteen, and I will tell you how to take a boat back south along the river.



TRACK 17

Panchganga Ghat, Where Five Rivers Meet

Well done. You have walked most of the length of old Kashi. You are now at Panchganga Ghat, one of the quieter, deeper, and more mysterious ghats on the river.

Panchganga means five rivers. According to tradition, five sacred rivers meet here. The Ganga, which you can see. And four more, the Yamuna, the Saraswati, the Kirana and the Dhutapapa, which you cannot. They are said to flow here hidden, underground or in spirit. Bathing at this spot, especially during the holy month of Kartik in autumn, is believed to carry special merit. You may see pilgrims carefully bathing here even when the other ghats are empty.

Look up above the steps. On the high ground stands a large mosque with white domes. It is commonly called the Alamgir Mosque, and also the Dharahara Mosque. It is generally said to have been built in the late seventeenth century, during the reign of the Mughal emperor Aurangzeb, whose title was Alamgir, on the site of an older Vishnu temple called

Bindu Madhav. It once had very tall minarets that were famous across the city, though they were damaged and shortened long ago. The new Bindu Madhav temple stands close by. This is one of the places where you can feel the complicated, layered history of Kashi most directly. Empires came and went. Temples were destroyed and rebuilt. Through it all, people kept coming down these steps to the river every morning.

Panchganga is also connected to a much-loved story about the poet and mystic Kabir, who lived in Varanasi in the fifteenth century and whose verses are still sung all over India. Kabir, the legend says, wanted to become a disciple of the great teacher Ramananda, but feared he would be refused. So, before dawn, he lay down on the steps of this ghat, where Ramananda came to bathe. In the darkness, Ramananda stepped on him, and in surprise cried out the name of Ram. Kabir took that word as his initiation. Whether it happened that way or not, it is a perfect Kashi story. Sometimes the teaching finds you by stepping on you.

Look also for a tall stone pillar near the ghat, studded with small niches. On the festival of Dev Deepawali, the festival of lights of the gods, which falls on the full moon of Kartik, usually in November, little lamps are placed in all those niches, and the pillar blazes with fire. On that night, the entire riverfront, every ghat from Assi to here, is lit with countless clay lamps. If you are ever in Varanasi at that time, it is unforgettable. Just book everything, especially boats, far in advance.

Close by is Balaji Ghat, where the shehnai maestro Ustad Bismillah Khan is remembered to have practised as a young man, his music drifting over the water. Kashi has always been a city of sound.

Here is my practical tip. Panchganga is a good place to end your walk. The lanes behind it are very old, very narrow and very confusing, so if you plan to walk back through the city rather than by the river, go back the way you came along the ghats, or take a boat. track eighteen will tell you how.

When you are ready, press play on track eighteen.



TRACK 18

Taking a Boat Back South

You have walked from Assi to the north end of old Kashi. Your feet are probably telling you so. The good news is that there is a beautiful way to go back. By the river.

Boats are everywhere along the ghats, and the boatmen will usually find you before you find them. Here is how to do it well.

First, decide what kind of boat you want. There are two main kinds. The traditional wooden boat, rowed by hand with long oars, is quiet, slow and lovely. You glide along close to the ghats and see everything you have just walked past from a completely new angle. Then there are motorboats, which are faster and noisier and cost somewhat more. For the journey back south, either works. If you are not in a hurry, choose the rowing boat. The silence is part of the experience.

Second, know the fair price before you start talking. For a private boat, for your group alone, a fair rate is roughly eight hundred to fifteen

hundred rupees for about an hour, depending on the season, the time of day, and how many people are on board. On festival days and around the evening aarti, prices go up. There are also shared boats, especially around the central ghats, where you join other passengers. For a shorter shared ride, you might pay something like thirty to a hundred rupees per person, and for longer, scenic shared rides more. The first price you hear will almost always be higher than fair. That is not rudeness. That is just the opening line of a conversation.

Third, agree on three things before you step in. The price. The duration, or the exact ghat where you want to be dropped. And whether the price is for the whole boat or per person. Say it clearly, for example, private boat, to Assi Ghat, one hour, how much? If the answer is far above the range I gave you, say thank you, and walk to the next boat. There will always be another boat. Saying I will look around is your most powerful tool, and many boatmen will call you back with a better price.

Fourth, ask the boatman not to stop anywhere along the way unless you ask. Sometimes a boat will pause near Manikarnika, and someone on the shore will ask for a donation for wood. You already know about that. Politely tell the boatman, no stops, just the river.

Fifth, pay at the end, not at the beginning. A small advance is fine if the boatman insists, but settle the full amount when you arrive.

And a word on safety. Most boats on the ghats do not carry life jackets. If that worries you, ask before agreeing. Children especially should wear one. Sit low and in the middle, do not stand up suddenly, and keep your phone on a strap or in a zipped pocket. The Ganga is gentle here most of the year, but it is a big river with real currents.

If it is dark, the ride back can be magical, with the lamps and fires of the ghats reflected in the water. If it is sunrise, the light will be pouring onto the faces of the buildings. Either way, as you pass each ghat, see if you can remember its story. The fort of the escaping king. The poet's steps. The striped steps of Kedar. The palace with the early lift. The queen who

rebuilt Kashi. The place of the ten horse sacrifices. The astronomer's roof. The wooden temple from Nepal. The fires that never go out. The temple that leans to listen.

When you are settled in your boat, or back at your guesthouse with a cup of chai, press play on the final track.



TRACK 19

What Kashi Gives You

Thank you for walking with me.

I want to tell you something that people from Varanasi know, but rarely say out loud. This city is not easy. It is loud, crowded, dusty, chaotic, sometimes frustrating, occasionally overwhelming. Cows block your path. Motorbikes appear out of nowhere in lanes too narrow for them. Someone is always trying to sell you something. And then, in the middle of all that, you turn a corner, and there is the river, wide and calm, and an old man sitting on the steps with his eyes closed, completely at peace. And suddenly, none of the noise matters.

That is the gift of Kashi. It holds everything at once. Birth and death. Prayer and business. Ancient and brand new. Grief and celebration. Fire and water. It does not separate them neatly the way the rest of the world tries to. It just puts them all on the same stone steps, by the same river, and lets you look.

People say you do not choose to come to Kashi. Kashi calls you. I used to think that was just a nice line for tourists. But I have met so many people who came for two days and stayed two months. Who came as tourists and left as something else. Who came looking for an exotic photograph and went home with a question they could not stop thinking about.

You have now walked past nearly three thousand years of stories. Gods and kings, poets and astronomers, queens and boatmen. But the most important story on these ghats is not any of the legends. It is the ordinary one. The woman who comes down to bathe every morning, as her mother did. The boatman whose grandfather rowed the same water. The child selling lamps at dusk. The family saying goodbye at the fire. That story is still being written, every day, and today, for a little while, you were part of it.

If this tour helped you, there is more on KashiGo, at [kashigo dot in](http://kashigo.in). You will find honest guides to the city, fair prices for everything from boats to rickshaws, and, if you would like to see the aarti from the water, fixed-price boat rides with local boatmen. And if you have a moment, I would be grateful if you told a friend about this walk. That is how a small Varanasi brand grows. One traveller at a time.

Before you go, do one last thing for me. Wherever you are, close your eyes for a moment. Picture the river at dawn. The mist. The first bell. The first bather stepping into the water.

Now open them. Kashi will still be there, whenever you come back. And you will come back. Almost everyone does.

Har Har Mahadev. Go well, my friend.



Route Card

For the PDF companion. Not narrated. Walking times are approximate, at an easy pace, between stops; add time for listening, chai and crowds.

- **Start: Assi Ghat** — Track 2. Southern end of the riverfront. Face the river, turn left, and walk north with the river on your right for the rest of the tour.
- **Tulsi Ghat** — Track 3. About 5 minutes from Assi.
- **Bhadaini, Janaki, Anandamayi, Jain Ghats** □ **Chet Singh Ghat** — Track 4. About 10 minutes from Tulsi. Look for the pumping station at Bhadaini, then the fort-like palace on the water.
- **Shivala Ghat and Hanuman Ghat** — Track 5. About 5 minutes from Chet Singh, past Niranjani and Mahanirvani Ghats.
- **Harishchandra Ghat (cremation)** — Track 6. About 3 minutes from Hanuman Ghat, past Karnataka Ghat. No photos.
- **Kedar Ghat** — Track 7. About 3 minutes. Red-and-white striped steps.

- **Mansarovar, Narad and Chausatthi Ghats** — Track 8. About 5–7 minutes.
- **Darbhangha and Munshi Ghats** — Track 9. About 3 minutes. Tall sandstone palace, now a heritage hotel.
- **Ahilyabai Ghat** — Track 10. About 2 minutes.
- **Dashashwamedh Ghat** — Tracks 11 and 12. About 3 minutes. Evening Ganga Aarti: roughly 6 pm in winter, closer to 7 pm in summer; arrive 45 minutes early.
- **Prayag and Rajendra Prasad Ghats** □ **Man Mandir Ghat** — Track 13. About 3 minutes. Rajput palace and Jantar Mantar observatory on the roof (small entry fee; check hours).
- **Tripura Bhairavi, Meer and Lalita Ghats** — Track 14. About 5 minutes. Look for the dark wooden Nepali temple.
- **Manikarnika Ghat (cremation)** — Track 15. About 3 minutes. No photos, no video. Do not follow anyone up a staircase.
- **Ratneshwar leaning temple and Scindia Ghat** — Track 16. About 2–3 minutes past Manikarnika.
- **Optional: Panchganga Ghat and Alamgir Mosque** — Track 17. About 10 minutes further north.
- **Boat back south** — Track 18. Then Track 19 to close.

Totals: about 3.5–4 km along the river; roughly 60–75 minutes of pure walking; 2.5–3 hours with stops.

Key tips

- Best start: Assi at sunrise, or around 3:00–3:30 pm to reach Dashashwamedh for the aarti.
- Monsoon (roughly July–September): the river rises and the ghat path is often submerged. Check before you walk; use the lanes behind flooded sections; never wade.
- Carry small notes (₹10, ₹20, ₹50), water, a scarf, and slip-on shoes.
- No photos or video at Harishchandra or Manikarnika. Ever.

- The unasked help rule: if help is offered that you did not ask for, smile, say "no thank you," and keep walking.
- Ghats are public and free. There is no entry ticket to any ghat.
- No "wood donation" is needed at the cremation ghats. That request is a known scam.
- Sadhu photos: ask first and agree a small offering (₹20–50).
- Diya (floating lamp): about ₹10–20.
- Aarti: no official paid or VIP seats. The steps are free.
- Boat back: private boat roughly ₹800–1,500 per hour; shared boat roughly ₹30–100 per person for a short hop. Agree price, duration or drop-off ghat, and whole-boat vs per-person before boarding. Pay at the end. Ask for no stops.
- Ask about life jackets before agreeing to a boat; children should always wear one.
- Lost? Walk downhill to the river, or ask anyone "Ghat?" and follow the pointing hands.

More honest guides from a local at kashigo.in.



CONTINUE YOUR JOURNEY

More from KashiGo

Varanasi Insider Guide 2026

The practical Varanasi playbook: real prices, all 9 scams, the ghats that matter, food you can trust and a ready-to-use itinerary.

kashigo.in/guide

India Scam-Proof

The first-timer's field manual to every common tourist scam across India — with the exact words to say.

kashigo.in/shop

Kashi Unveiled

The meaning behind the rituals, temples, river and fire — a spiritual traveller's guide to Varanasi.

kashigo.in/shop

Free: Varanasi Scam Cheat Sheet

The one-page list to keep on your phone.

kashigo.in

A SMALL FAVOUR

If this book helped you, a short honest review on the store where you bought it helps other travellers find it — and means the world to a small Varanasi business. Thank you, and har har Mahadev.